UNIVERSITY OF LONDON

THE LONDON SCHOOL OF ECONOMICS AND POLITICAL SCIENCE

# Market Research Proposal

# Apple Inc.

Statistical methods for Market Research – ST3188

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# Executive summary

The focus of this research proposal is to address the research brief given by Apple Inc. Their four main business objectives are:

• Expanding global market share through product innovation and diversification of service offerings

• Driving growth via product development, ecosystem integration, and expansion into emerging markets

• Delivering exceptional user experiences using new technologies, seamless device integration, and personalized services

• Prioritizing privacy protection and environmental sustainability to achieve carbon neutrality across the business.

The proposal includes relevant market context on current market status globally and regionally in terms of market share and competition, as well as a review of key drivers such as AI integration, AR/VR trends, sustainability preferences, and barriers like pricing and ecosystem openness. These have been translated into specific marketing decisions and research problems that the proposal will focus on. An analytical model has been developed with research questions and hypotheses regarding the variables affecting consumer preferences, user satisfaction, privacy trust, sustainability impact, and market dominance, which can potentially impact growth and loyalty. The proposal also outlines the methods for primary data collection which will be done using online questionnaires. The research design, required fieldwork, sample frames, sample sizes, and sampling techniques, such as stratified and quota sampling have been suggested. Additionally, multivariate analysis techniques such as multiple linear regression, logistic regression, and cluster analysis have been suggested for data analysis. The proposal concludes with a mention of the timeframe of the research, along with further research that is needed to achieve the stated objectives if time and budget constraints permit.

# Background

Apple Inc. is a leading global technology company headquartered in Cupertino, California, United States. Founded on April 1, 1976, by Steve Jobs, Steve Wozniak, and Ronald Wayne as Apple Computer Company, it began with the development of personal computers like the Apple I and evolved into a consumer electronics giant with the launch of groundbreaking products such as the Macintosh in 1984 (Levy & Montevirgen, 2024). Apple designs, manufactures, and markets consumer electronics, software, and services across over 175 countries and territories, with a product portfolio including iPhone, iPad, Mac, Apple Watch, AirPods, Apple TV, and HomePod, alongside services like the App Store, Apple Music, iCloud, and Apple Pay. The company drives customer loyalty through its integrated ecosystem of hardware, software, and services, which fosters seamless device integration and personalized experiences (Apple, 2025).

Over the decades, Apple has expanded significantly, notably acquiring NeXT in 1996 to bring back Steve Jobs, Beats Electronics in 2014 for $3 billion to bolster Apple Music, and Shazam in 2018, among others, enhancing its technological and content offerings (Lunden & Roof, 2017). Apple is renowned for its commitment to exceptional user experiences, product innovation, and operational excellence, including its transition to its own Apple silicon chips starting in 2020. Financially, the company reported revenues

of approximately $416 billion in fiscal year 2025, up from $391 billion in 2024, with net income of $112 billion, reflecting robust growth in iPhone sales and ecosystem services (Elagina, 2026). Apple is committed to corporate social responsibility (CSR), focusing on environmental sustainability and privacy protection. Its 2030 plan aims for carbon neutrality across its footprint and has reduced global greenhouse gas emissions by over 60% since 2015. This includes using recycled materials, achieving 100% renewable energy for facilities, and low-carbon transportation. Apple also invested in the Clean Energy Fund in China and reached 99% recycled rare earth elements in magnets. Apple also strives for zero-waste operations and aims to eliminate plastics from packaging by 2025. Its commitments are further reflected in certifications like ISO 14001 and EPEAT Gold. Their sustainability efforts have been further showcased in the 2025 Environmental Progress Report. (Apple, 2025)

# Business objectives

- **Expand global market share** through product innovation and diversification of service offerings.

- **Drive growth** via product development, ecosystem integration, and expansion into emerging markets.

- Deliver exceptional **user experiences** using new technologies, seamless device integration, and personalized services.

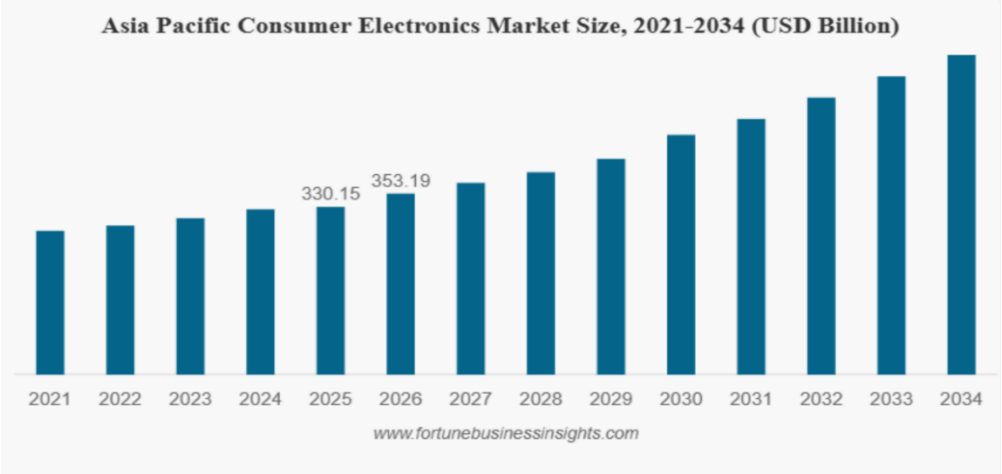
- Prioritize **privacy protection and environmental sustainability** to achieve carbon neutrality across the business.

# Research aims

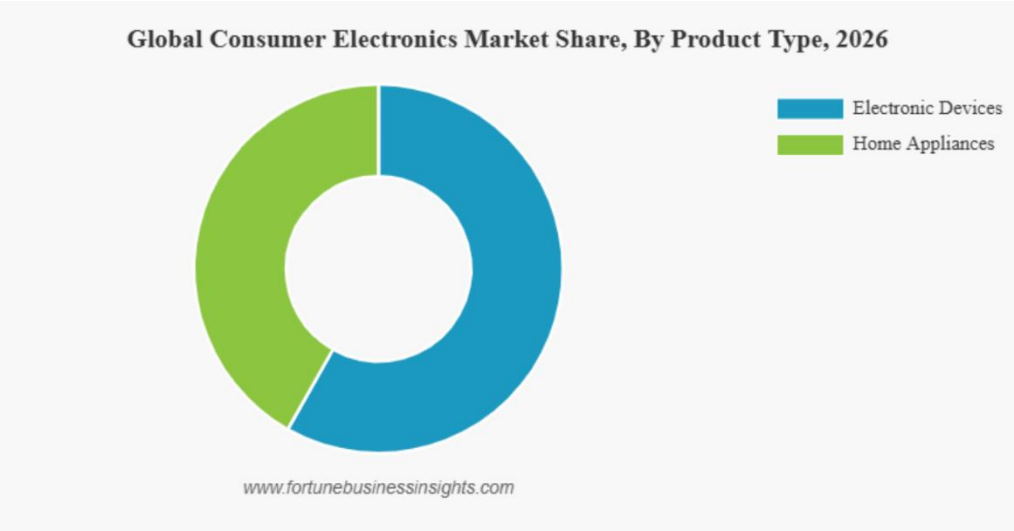
1. Consumer Preferences: Accurately understand consumer preferences for products, ecosystem integration, and service personalisation across devices.
2. Emerging Trends: Identify emerging trends and adoption patterns.
3. Customer Satisfaction: Assess customer satisfaction across product lines.
4. Privacy Impact: See the impact of privacy initiatives on trust and loyalty.
5. Demographic Analysis: Analyse preferences and behaviours of different segments (notably Gen Z and millennials).
6. Services Ecosystem Evaluation: Evaluate the effectiveness of the services ecosystem in driving device retention.
7. Economic Factors: Better understand how economic factors influence purchasing decisions to adapt pricing strategies.

# Market context

Apple Inc competes in the rapidly evolving consumer electronics market, projected to grow from USD 815.16 billion in 2024 to USD 1,467.94 billion by 2032, exhibiting a CAGR of 7.85%. Apple's revenues reached $390.8 billion in 2024, with projections for continued growth driven by hardware and services segments (Fortune Business Insights, 2026).



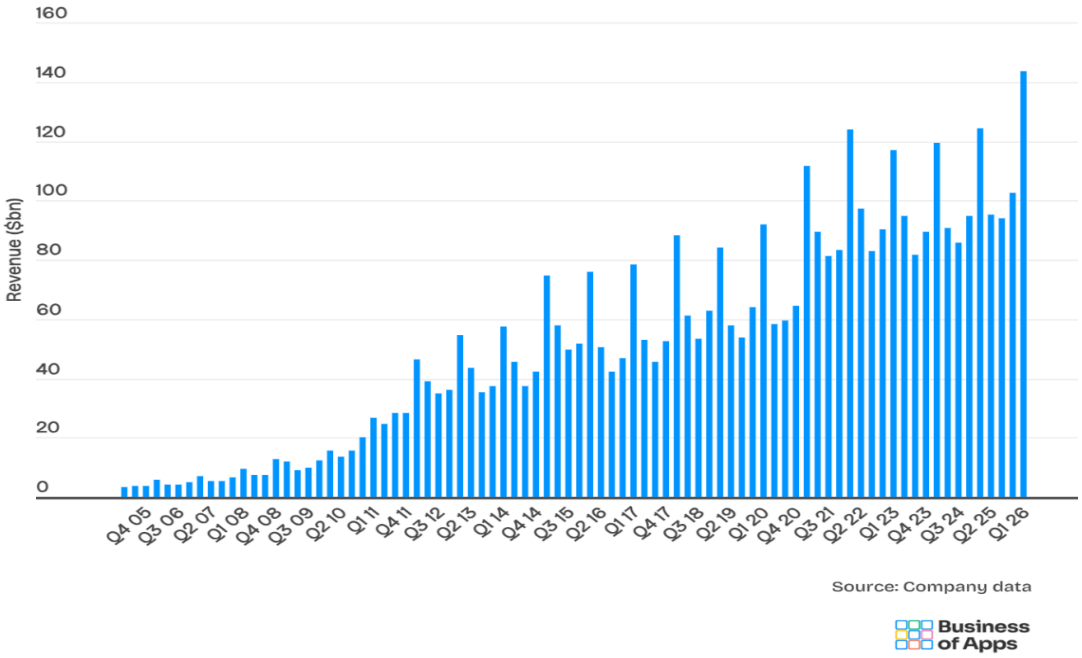
The key demand drivers for Apple Inc. include rising adoption of premium smartphones like the iPhone and wearables such as the Apple Watch in developed markets, expanding digital services like Apple Music and iCloud in emerging economies, and increasing enterprise demand for secure, integrated devices such as Macs and iPads as remote work persists. Emerging technologies such as Artificial Intelligence (AI) in features like Apple Intelligence, augmented reality (AR)/virtual reality (VR) with Vision Pro, and edge computing in Apple Silicon are significant industry trends, enhancing personalization, operational efficiency, and user experiences (Dudovskiy, 2023). Sustainability is crucial for Gen Z, with 73% willing to pay more for eco-friendly products. Apple's carbon-neutral initiatives, aiming for net-zero emissions by 2030, are highly valued. The company has received positive reviews for device reliability, ecosystem integration, and customer support on platforms like Trustpilot and Consumer Reports.




The current consumer clusters include tech-savvy professionals seeking productivity tools, Gen Z and Millennials prioritizing personalization and social features, and enterprise users focused on security and scalability (Green Earth, 2024). Key customer preferences include seamless ecosystem integration, privacy features, AI-driven personalization, and sustainability. To meet these needs, Apple utilizes data analytics

for personalized experiences while prioritizing on-device processing for privacy, invests in AI innovations like Apple Intelligence, and focuses on sustainability through recycled materials and renewable energy. The competitive landscape includes direct competitors like Samsung, Google, Microsoft, and Huawei, as well as platform rivals such as Amazon in services and streaming. Competition for market share is fierce, as these companies target similar consumer segments. Customers sometimes prefer Apple's rivals due to lower prices, more customization, open ecosystems, and wider hardware options, particularly in emerging markets. Apple has addressed these challenges through strategic acquisitions, expanding its ecosystem, diversifying into services and wearables, and leveraging innovative AI. The consumer electronics industry is influenced by factors such as economic conditions, political stability, regulations, and consumer confidence. Macro-economic elements such as exchange rates, inflation, and employment levels also affect consumer spending and Apple's revenue. Legally, compliance with antitrust laws, intellectual property regulations, data privacy standards, and labour laws is essential to ensure ethical operations (Lombardo, 2025).

Figure: Apple Revenue from 2005 to 2026 ($bn)



# Marketing Decision Problem

- How can Apple expand its global reach through product innovation and diversification of service offerings, and increase its market share
- What strategies, integration systems and development initiatives should Apple pursue to drive growth into emerging markets?
- What technologies and personalized services across products should Apple leverage to improve customer experience and satisfaction
- How can Apple prioritize privacy protections and environmental impact to achieve carbon neutrality across the business

# Marketing Research Problem

**Broad statement**

The research aims to explore how Apple can improve user experiences and satisfaction through personalized services, technology integration, and sustainability initiatives, while adapting to market dynamics and demographic preferences, compared to competitors such as Samsung, Google, and Microsoft.

**Key components**

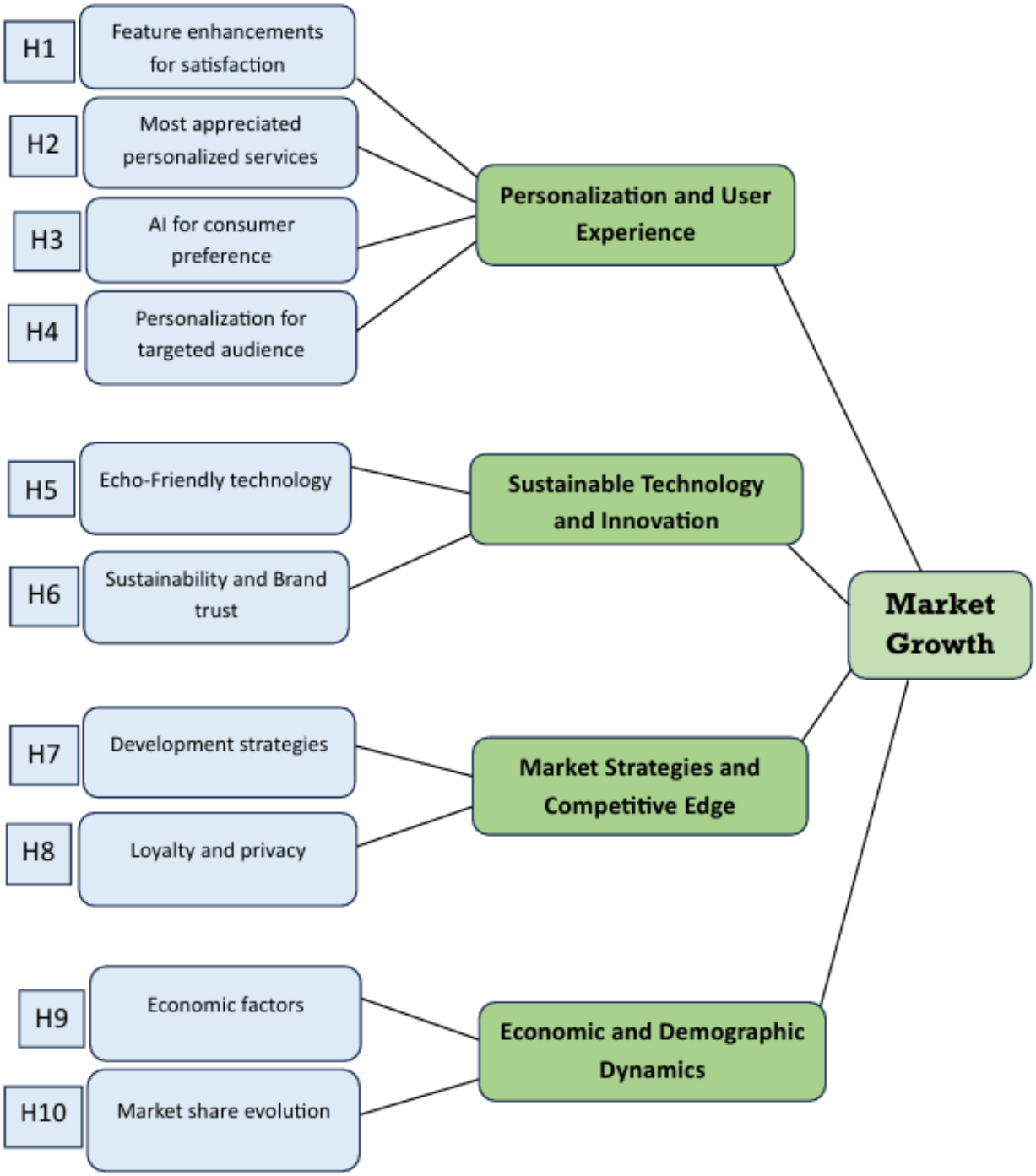
- Identify areas for improvement in user satisfaction and experience across Apple's product categories, services, and regions.
- Understand the impact of personalized services, ecosystem integration, and technology advancements on consumer preferences and the electronics industry.
- Evaluate how Apple's privacy protection and sustainability initiatives affect user trust, loyalty, retention, and brand image.

- Analyse trends, economic factors, and demographic behaviours (Gen Z and millennials) affecting purchasing decisions, while noting opportunities and threats for market expansion.

## Research questions

1. What changes could be made to the existing features to enhance user satisfaction across all services provided?
2. What personalized services are appreciated the most by Apple customers?
3. What personalized trends and services drive the targeted audiences in their purchasing decision?
4. How can Artificial Intelligence be leveraged to enhance consumer preference across all product categories?
5. What technological advancements can be made to promote an eco-friendly user experience on all products and services?
6. What Eco-friendly and sustainability initiatives have influenced Apple consumers' trust, improving its brand image?
7. How does Apple's global customer loyalty differentiate itself from competitors (Samsung, Microsoft, etc.) despite privacy concerns regarding data collection?
8. What development strategies across all product categories could assert market dominance across different regions?
9. Which economic factors affect the majority of consumers' preference for Apple, despite the availability of budget-friendly options from competitors?
10. How does market share evolve in relation to demographic behaviour across different regions?

# Analytical Model



# Hypotheses

**H1**: Improving existing features like seamless device switching and easier controls will greatly increase user satisfaction across all Apple services.

**H2**: Apple customers value personalized services the most when they involve health tracking, smart recommendations, and smooth integration between devices.

**H3**: Using AI to deliver more personal and helpful features will make consumers prefer Apple products even more across all categories.

**H4**: AR features, social sharing tools, and wellness options are the main trends that drive younger buyers to choose Apple over its competitors (Samsung, Google).

**H5**: Adding more recycled materials and energy-saving technologies to products will create a better, eco-friendly experience for users.

**H6**: Apple's efforts in using recycled materials and clean energy build stronger trust with customers and improve the brand's image.

**H7**: Creating products and strategies tailored to each region will help Apple gain stronger market leadership worldwide.

**H8**: Apple's focus on privacy and its complete ecosystem keeps customers more loyal than competitors, even when privacy concerns arise.

**H9**: Perceived quality, durability, and status make most consumers choose Apple over cheaper alternatives, regardless of price.

**H10**: Apple's market share grows fastest in regions with more young people because they are drawn to innovative and trendy products.

# Research design

The research involves problem-identification, horizon-scanning, and understanding market phenomena such as consumer behaviour, brand perceptions, and competition, requiring **exploratory research** to formulate hypotheses for decision-making. A well-structured research design that correlates with the research aims of Apple is crucial for this proposal, addressing key areas like personalization, sustainability, market dominance, and consumer loyalty in a dynamic tech landscape. **Descriptive Research** is identified as having significant alignment with Apple's research aims, as it quantifies aspects such as consumer satisfaction, preferences, and perceptions across product categories, regions, and demographics, answering who, what, where, when, and how questions to project findings to a larger population. The research will also focus on consumer trends, government policies, competitor analysis, advertising methods, and product usage of the target population. **Conclusive research** will hence be used to identify relationships between the variables influencing customer attitudes towards Apple's ecosystem and devices, and to test and validate the hypotheses.

# Fieldwork

In the fieldwork, the data collection process will utilize a **multiple-sample cross-sectional** approach, gathering information from distinct groups at a single point per group. This method fits the study's needs, given the diverse audience of Apple device owners and users of rival brands like Samsung or Google, who require independent sampling to compare preferences and behaviours accurately. Responses will be obtained through a digital survey distributed to various participant segments over a six-month period. **Web-based questionnaires** (Q&A's) offer straightforward deployment, uniform response gathering, and streamlined evaluation. For Apple users, the questionnaire will be delivered online and via messaging, while competitors will receive AI-assisted face-to-face questioning. It can be presented as an interactive prompt on Apple's site or promoted digitally, starting with a filter to identify Apple

users. **Digital questionnaires** are engaging visually and extend to a broad audience. They support tailored response paths via built-in logic, eliminate external influence, and enable rapid rollout to participants. That said, participation levels can be modest, but this may be boosted by **offering rewards** for completers, such as a raffle entry for an Apple Gift Card usable in the App Store or a complimentary month of Apple One services for Apple enthusiasts, and a general tech voucher for competitor users. **Follow-up notifications** can be shared on online platforms to enhance turnout. **Direct outreach via messaging** to Apple owners can leverage publicly available opt-in lists or partnered panels, with adaptive question flows for customized inquiries. Such messaging avoids outside interference, though uptake is often limited; rewards and subsequent reminders can lift involvement. Messages should be crafted to **bypass filtering mechanisms**. For rival-brand users, in-person sessions in high-traffic areas like shopping centres can help gather targeted outreach details. Interviewers can engage relevant individuals and note device types on-site. These sessions boost participation, handle complex questions, and include demonstrations, though they require trained personnel and incur costs.

# Sampling design

## Target population

The individuals of interest encompass both Apple ecosystem participants and those engaging with primary rival offerings, which can be segmented as follows:

1. Users primarily within the Apple ecosystem (encompassing devices like iPhone, iPad, Mac, Apple Watch, and associated services such as Apple Music or iCloud).
2. Users favouring competitor ecosystems (including Samsung's Galaxy lineup and services, Google's Pixel and Android-based tools, or Microsoft's Surface and Windows-integrated products). This grouping captures a broad spectrum

without limiting to specific age, income, or other traits, aligning to encompass diverse consumer insights. Apple's global operations involve data gathering over six months.

## Sampling Frame

For participants in the *Apple ecosystem, the provided client database of individuals who have made purchases via Apple ID will serve as the reference list*. Initial filter items in the questionnaire will address any mismatches, such as inactive users, and adjustments like weighting can align the collected data with known population patterns. For those aligned with *competitor ecosystems, a structured reference list isn't necessary, as the approach relies on non-random selection methods.*

## Sample Sizes

- Apple ecosystem users: 5,000 allocated proportionally across key operational areas based on Apple's revenue distribution as a proxy for market presence. This ensures representation reflects global footprint while allowing in-depth examination of preferences, trends, and satisfaction metrics. Research indicates an average completion rate of 87% for such surveys (Survey Monkey, 2025). Incidence rates for screened individuals are estimated at 85% for targeted customers and 75% for non-customers. The effective qualification rate is the product of incidence and completion rates. For Apple users: 0.85 × 0.87 = 0.7395. Thus, the initial contact size needed to achieve 5,000 completes is 5,000 / 0.7395 ≈ 6,762.
- Competitor ecosystem users: Total of 5,000, split as 2,500 for Android-focused users and 2,500 for PC/service-oriented users. This balanced total matches the Apple sample for robust comparisons, providing sufficient statistical reliability for identifying differences in behaviours, loyalty, and economic influences without overextending resources. A larger sample may increase costs and

timelines, while a smaller one limits subgroup analysis. A sample of 5,000 strikes an optimal balance for both exploratory and conclusive insights within six months, minimizing variability errors and allowing for broader projections. Using the same benchmarks, the effective rate for competitors is 0.75 × 0.87 = 0.6525. Therefore, the initial contact size required for 5,000 completes is 5,000 / 0.6525 ≈ 7,663.

## Sampling Techniques

The study will incorporate a mix of random and selective methods (both **probability** and **non-probability sampling techniques**) to achieve coverage and efficiency.

For ***Apple ecosystem users***, **stratified sampling** will be applied, using geographic areas as the primary division to account for worldwide dispersion, creating five key layers. This promotes similarity within each layer and variation across them, yielding a balanced overview. Within layers, **simple random sampling** will identify units, followed by further categorization by factors like age brackets (including Gen Z and Millennials for targeted trend analysis), earnings, and product usage to distribute the questionnaire effectively.

For ***competitor ecosystem users***, **quota sampling** fits well, given predefined targets for Android and PC/service groups. This entails setting categories (Android-focused and PC/service-oriented) along with assigned numbers from each, then choosing participants through accessible means and evaluator discretion. Suitable venues include retail outlets or tech events for assessors to identify individuals based on device preferences. To enhance the digital approach, online access panels or targeted ads on social networks can help diversify recruitment. For hard-to-reach segments, expert-guided selection can refine choices.

# Multivariate Analysis

**Multiple Linear Regression** will be the primary technique for causal hypotheses, examining how independent variables predict outcomes while adjusting for covariates. The model could regress consumer preference scores on AI feature usage while controlling for product category, age, and income. Similarly, sustainability initiatives would analyse trust and loyalty based on exposure to Apple's recycled materials campaigns and "Apple 2030" carbon-neutral efforts, considering economic factors like perceived durability and status. Beta coefficients will indicate effect sizes, with R-squared assessing explained variance. Recent Q1 2026 earnings highlight AI's role in driving 15.7% revenue growth, informing variable selection for real-world relevance. (Mymotherlode, 2026)

**Logistic Regression**: For binary or categorical outcomes, such as loyalty differentiation amid privacy concerns, this will predict the probability of ecosystem retention (e.g., 92% vs. competitors' lower rates) based on privacy features like App Tracking Transparency. Odds ratios will quantify impacts, with pseudo-R-squared evaluating fit. This aligns with 2026 news on Apple's privacy-focused AI strategy, offsetting data risks.

**Cluster Analysis**: Hierarchical clustering (Ward's method with Euclidean distance) followed by k-means will segment respondents by behaviours, e.g., grouping Gen Z/Millennials based on AR/VR trends and wellness tools, or by regions for market share evolution. By identifying distinct user profiles, Apple can tailor strategies for ecosystem retention, personalization, and competitive positioning. For example, distinguishing "tech-savvy early adopters" who prioritize AI features like enhanced Siri in iOS 18.4 from "value-oriented" users sensitive to economic factors amid 2026's inflationary pressures.

# Further Research

Further research will need to address key limitations to enhance reliability. The sample size, while substantial at 5,000 for Apple ecosystem users and 5,000 for competitors, may not fully represent Apple's vast global user base in the tech sector, potentially introducing bias. Scaling up samples to include more participants across product categories, regions, demographics, and specialized groups can enhance inclusivity and diversity.

Additionally, the six-month timeframe restricts tracking of rapidly shifting tech trends, such as AI adoption and economic influences on preferences. Extending the period would enable longitudinal methods to monitor these dynamics more effectively, providing richer analytical depth.

Relying heavily on digital surveys may reduce participation, particularly among older or less tech-savvy individuals. Incorporating phone interviews, in-person sessions, or hybrid formats would improve response rates and data accuracy.

Other factors include managing multicollinearity in regression models and advanced causal assessments. Privacy concerns and participant consent must be carefully handled to align with Apple’s user data protection standards. Addressing these issues will enhance the research's validity and lead to more strategic outcomes.

# Questionnaire

**Apple Inc. - Consumer Experiences and Preferences Survey**

Welcome to Apple Inc.'s official consumer experiences and preferences survey. Thank you for taking the time to fill out and complete the questionnaire.

If you are an ***Apple customer***, you will be rewarded with a ***50% discount on a 3-month subscription to Apple One*** for completing the survey, and ***a 25% discount if you are not***. The estimated time to complete the survey is 10 minutes.

Your insights are invaluable in helping us improve our services and your technology experience. The responses and personal information you provide will solely be used for research purposes and kept confidential.

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**Part A: General Consumer Technology Preferences**

- World map with devices like iPhone, Mac, and connections illustrating the global tech ecosystem

1. How often do you purchase or upgrade consumer electronics (e.g., smartphones, laptops, wearables) per year?

   1-2 times ☐ 3-5 times ☐ 6-10 times ☐ More than 10 times ☐ I do not purchase consumer electronics ☐

2. What are the factors that influence your choice of technology brand? (Select all that apply)

   Price ☐ Brand Reputation ☐ Ecosystem Integration ☐ Personalization Features ☐ Privacy and Security ☐ Sustainability Practices ☐ Technological Innovations (e.g., AI, AR/VR) ☐ Other (Please Specify):

   _____

3. Have you used or owned an Apple product (e.g., iPhone, Mac, Apple Watch) in the past 2 years?

   Yes ☐ No ☐

- If Yes, go to Part B. If No, go to Part C.

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**Part B: Apple Customers**

1. How satisfied are you with the following aspects of Apple products and services? (Rate on a scale of 1-5, where 1 = Very Dissatisfied and 5 = Very Satisfied)

- Device Performance and Reliability

  **1☐ 2☐ 3☐ 4☐ 5☐**

- Ecosystem Integration (e.g., seamless syncing across devices)

  **1☐ 2☐ 3☐ 4☐ 5☐**

- Personalization and AI Features (e.g., Siri, Apple Intelligence)

  **1☐ 2☐ 3☐ 4☐ 5☐**

- Privacy and Security Features

  **1**☐ **2**☐ **3**☐ **4**☐ **5**☐

- Sustainability Initiatives (e.g., recycled materials, carbon neutrality)

  **1**☐ **2**☐ **3**☐ **4**☐ **5**☐

- Services (e.g., App Store, Apple Music, iCloud)

  **1**☐ **2**☐ **3**☐ **4**☐ **5**☐

2. How long have you been an Apple customer?

_____ (e.g., years or months)

3. How important are sustainability initiatives when choosing technology products?

(Not Important) **1**☐ **2**☐ **3**☐ **4**☐ **5**☐ (Very Important)

4. How did you learn about Apple's sustainability efforts? (Select all that apply)
   I am unaware ☐ Apple's website ☐ Social-media ☐ Email newsletters ☐
   In-product notifications ☐ Other (Please Specify):
   _____

5. How likely are you to choose Apple again for future purchases?

   Very Unlikely ☐ Unlikely ☐ Neutral ☐ Likely ☐ Very Likely ☐

6. What improvements would enhance your Apple experience?

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7. What personalized services do you appreciate the most in Apple products? (Select all that apply)

Health tracking☐ Smart-recommendations (Siri suggestions, etc.)☐ Seamless device integration☐ Customizable interfaces☐ Other (Please Specify):

_____

8. How has Apple's use of AI (e.g., in features like Apple Intelligence) influenced your preference for their products?

   (Not at All) **1** ☐ **2** ☐ **3** ☐ **4** ☐ **5** ☐ (Very Much)

9. How do Apple's privacy protections affect your trust and loyalty?

   (Decreases Trust) **1** ☐ **2** ☐ **3** ☐ **4** ☐ **5** ☐ (Increases Trust)

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**Part C: Non-Apple Customers**

1. What technology brands do you usually use? (Select all that apply)
   Samsung ☐ Google ☐ Microsoft ☐ Huawei ☐
   Other (Please Specify): _____

2. What factors have prevented you from using Apple products? (Select all that apply)

   Price ☐ Brand Preference ☐ Lack of Customization ☐ Ecosystem Compatibility Issues ☐ Privacy Concerns ☐ Sustainability Practices ☐ Lack of Technological Features ☐ Other (Please Specify):

   _____

3. How familiar are you with Apple's loyalty and ecosystem features (e.g., Apple One, iCloud)?

   Very Familiar ☐ Somewhat Familiar ☐ Not Familiar ☐

4. Would sustainability initiatives influence your decision to try Apple products?
   Yes ☐ No ☐ Unsure ☐

5. What would encourage you to consider purchasing an Apple product?

   _____

6. How do economic factors (e.g., price, perceived value) influence your preference for competitors over Apple?

   (Not at All) **1** ☐ **2** ☐ **3** ☐ **4** ☐ **5** ☐ (Very Much)

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**Part D: Demographic and Geographic Information**

[Global network image with diverse people connected by technology]

1. What is your age category?
   Under 20 ☐ 20-35 ☐ 36-50 ☐ 51-65 ☐ 65+ ☐

2. What is your gender?

   Male ☐ Female ☐ Other ☐ Prefer Not to Specify ☐

3. What is your ethnicity?

   Caucasian ☐ Hispanic or Latino ☐ Black or African American ☐ Native American ☐ Asian or Pacific Islander ☐ Other ☐

4. What is your country of residence?

   Select Country ▼

5. What is your annual income bracket?

   Less than $25,000 ☐ $25,000-$50,000 ☐ $50,000-$75,000 ☐ $75,000-$100,000 ☐ $100,000-$200,000 ☐ More than $200,000 ☐

6. Do you intend on purchasing a new technology device in the next 12 months?
   Yes ☐ No ☐ Unsure ☐

7. If yes, would you consider Apple products? (If No, please specify)

   Yes ☐ No ☐: _____

**THANK YOU**

Your responses have been recorded and will significantly help us improve Apple Inc.'s services. You are now eligible for a discount on Apple services (based on your Apple customer status), and you can redeem it here. We appreciate your time and look forward to welcoming you in the future!

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